

Nurturing birds labor of love at Raptor Center

Many visitors to the Carolina Raptor Center mispronounce the name as the "rapture center".

When staring into the huge yellow eyes of a great horned owl, it's easy to get the two words confused.

The center gives visitors a rare close-up look at birds of prey that are normally seen only as small specks, floating far above the earth.

The center rehabilitates injured raptors and releases them back to the wild when possible. Many of them, however, would never make it in their natural world and are taken care of for life at the center.

Raptor Center volunteer Claude Ross has been taught to handle many of the birds. His favorite is Dudley, a great horned owl.

"Dudley's problem is, he's mixed up. Dudley is confused. He thinks he's a little person that just happens to have feathers," Ross said, explaining why Dudley will never be released.

"Dudley was raised by people. People fed him and took care of him. He would think, 'Well, Mom and Dad are feeding me again' and came to think he was a person. He doesn't want anything to do with other great horned owls.

"In addition to being confused, the people fed Dudley the wrong kind of food. We X-rayed him to see why he doesn't fly better than he does, and found out that his bones are deformed. The people fed him hamburgers and hotdogs."

It is illegal to keep or handle a raptor without a special federal license. Even taking a feather from one of these birds is illegal.

Wingate resident Lessie Davis took a baby great horned owl to the center a few weeks ago after it fell out of its nest. She worried that the parents would not return to care for the owlet after being spooked away when their nest tilted. The owlet will be raised at the center by adult owls that are permanently confined there because of injuries. He'll eventually go back to the wild.

The most common reason for owls getting harmed is car accidents.

Owls often hunt mice along the roadside. "Mice are attracted to the side of the road because people have thrown out that last little bit of a



hamburger that they didn't want," Ross said. Owls are low, slow, night flyers, and drivers don't see the owls.

Other birds of prey, like eagles, falcons and hawks, wind up at the center when they've been preyed upon by hunters.

Ross also likes to handle Sigmund, a red-tailed hawk who "has a tendency to fly in circles" due to a gunshot wound.

The Raptor Center cares for many birds that only have one wing, like bald eagles, Queen Charlotte and Sir Raleigh.

Although the eagles will never fly again, their love lives still soar.

The pair has been mating for years, producing healthy eaglets that the center has released into the wild.

Volunteers do not handle chicks born at the center at all. The parents take care of their young until they are old enough to be released.

The center releases many eagles in Hyde County at Lake Mattamuskeet.

Peregrine falcons can also be found in North Carolina. The center has taken in at least two peregrines that were found in downtown Charlotte.

"They see a tall building and think it's just another mountain, so they head downtown," Ross said. The center has about 20 different species of raptors that are on view alongside an outdoor trail.

The public is not admitted to other parts of the center consisting of the raptor hospital, and several acres reserved for rehabilitation, breeding, and flight cages for recuperating birds.

The Raptor Center operates almost entirely on a volunteer basis. Volunteers have the opportunity to learn about handling, daily care, and rehabilitation.

The center got its start in 1978 when someone brought an injured owl to a biology student at UNCC, knowing that she liked birds. Within a year, Deborah Sue Griffin had six birds, and began enlisting the help of other students to care for them. The biology department let the students use the basement of the building to keep the birds.

Within a few years there were around 200 birds being cared for in the basement. Volunteers would let them fly up and down the halls for exercise. One day a black vulture named Kendall got on the elevator



At top, Raptor Center volunteer Claude Ross shows off Sigmund, a red-tailed hawk who was shot by a hunter and can only fly in circles. At left is Serena, an eastern screech owl. She is missing her right eye and is blind in the left one after being hit by a car. Above is Dudley, a great horned owl who won't have anything to do with other owls after being raised by human beings. He can't fly very well because he was not fed the right things. Below is the Raptor Center, home to all these and many more troubled birds of prey.

Text by **Nicci Chen**
Photos by **Hope Shaffer**

and wound up on the third floor, scaring some people when he casually walked off.

"That's when they really realized that they needed to find another location," said Pat Marcum, the center's executive director.

In 1981 the center officially became a non-profit, tax-exempt operation. In 1985, it moved to its current location.

The center is completely dependent upon public contributions and the occasional corporate grant.

Memberships can be purchased, with the cost starting at \$25 for a contributing member, on up to \$1,000 to be a benefactor.

Individuals or groups can also "adopt" a bird. The center will send you a picture of your bird, a biogra-

phy, and an adoption certificate, along with providing visitation rights. Adoption fees vary from \$25 for a small owl, kestrel, or merlin, to \$300 for an eagle.

Want to go?

The center is located in Charlotte in Latta Plantation Park off of Beattie's Ford Road.

Visiting hours are from 10 a.m. to 5 p.m., Tuesday through Sunday, weather permitting.

Admission is \$2 for adults and \$1 for senior citizens and students. Members are admitted free. Family memberships are \$30. The phone number is (704) 875-6521.

